Sustaining Effective Leadership in Urgent Environments: Integrating Self-Awareness, Transparency, and Psychological Safety

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Introduction

A student emails or calls needing accommodations yesterday. I figure out how to make it work; I start the search for a Sighted Aide with the only context of the course being the CRN, I lose my break and lunch catching up from the back-to-back meetings already on my calendar, without saying anything. This repeats itself dozens of times each semester in my position as an Accommodation Specialist at WMU's Disability Services for Students.

Could the student have been more proactive? Students could always be more proactive, but urgent access needs will always arise. The individual in this situation that needed to adjust was me. I started this class wondering how leaders in these situations can sustain their capacity and well-being. More specifically, how can self-awareness, transparency, and psychological safety help?

Five weeks (and many more readings) into PADM 6290: Leadership & Supervision, I am convinced sustainable leadership in high-urgency environments requires these three concepts in concert: Objective self-awareness (developed with external input), transparency about cost & limits, and psychological safety to speak up before a crisis.

Leadership Literature & Sustainability: How We See & Don't See Ourselves

Leaders need self-awareness to make decisions that positively impact their teams. But how can leaders know where they need to grow if they're blind to their own habits? Kaplan and Kaiser's (2003) study that leadership self-ratings do not correlate when lined up with how others see you. Leaders are literally the last person who can accurately identify their own weakness. This article stopped me in my tracks, and put me immediately into self-reflection.

Leaders grow through experience and learning from those doing the work. Day et al. (2014) got me thinking about how leaders need to learn from those doing the work. More importantly, they cited research that “time in service and number of previous positions were unrelated to leadership performance” (Day et al., 2014, p. 66). Leaders cannot become experts simply by spending enough time in a position. They have to make learning about how the work gets done and what it requires of people in those positions. Proximity does not equate to experience. You could be standing directly to someone and if they have an umbrella in the rain and you don’t, you’re going to get wet.

Reading these articles, I’ve realized that I’ve been avoiding this learning in my current job. By taking care of urgent matters without voicing their cost to the team, I’m hiding how my work demands affect my team.

Benmira and Agboola (2021) argue that leadership theory evolved precisely because no single style fits every situation. I observed that supervising interpreter scheduling requires transactional leadership, while advocating for an accessibility initiative requires transformational leadership. The problem the authors acknowledge but do not resolve is crucial: how does a leader recognize the moment to switch styles before damage occurs? This question became sharper when I read Kaplan and Kaiser alongside their work. If leaders are blind to their own patterns, they may not recognize a style mismatch until after it has cost them trust.

Lewis (2022) offers a behavioral answer: trust is built through transparency, and transparency begins with self-awareness. Lewis prescribes a solution that assumes the very capacity Kaplan and Kaiser suggest is unreliable; accurate self-perception. This exposed a gap in the literature itself: versatility requires seeing yourself clearly, but research suggests

leaders cannot do this alone. The antidote, I realized, is not better self-awareness in isolation, it is external feedback that corrects the leader's blind spot.

Cheung-Judge (2012) and Boyatzis et al. (2006) both address what happens when leaders do not invest in self-knowledge and external feedback: burnout. Cheung-Judge's second group—leaders who are effective but sliding toward burnout—described exactly what I was doing that Sighted Aide week. Boyatzis et al. add a physiological dimension: chronic leadership stress triggers the sympathetic nervous system, degrading health if unaddressed, while genuine compassion toward others activates the parasympathetic nervous system as an antidote. Both authors converge on one insight: sustainability requires intentional investment. No one else will do it for you.

Finally, the Center for Creative Leadership (2025) and Edmondson and Besieux (2021) address how conversation quality shapes team dynamics. CCL offers tactics for difficult conversations already happening; Edmondson and Besieux offer strategy for building conditions where difficult conversations happen sooner. Both assume, however, that a baseline of psychological safety exists. The tension this creates in urgent environments: what happens when resource constraints make safety feel impossible? This question remains open in the literature.

The Framework: Self-Knowledge, Transparency, and Psychological Safety as Integrated Practice

What emerges from this reading is a progression. Sustainable leadership does not begin with better communication or stronger team culture. It begins with accurate self-knowledge, specifically understanding how others experience your patterns and where your

blind spots live. Kaplan and Kaiser (2003) are the foundation: leaders need external feedback to see themselves clearly.

That self-knowledge then makes transparency possible. When I finally acknowledge to my Director and team that an urgent response cost me skipped breaks and rushed meetings, I am not complaining, I am modeling that costs are real and matter. This is where Lewis (2022) really stuck with me: silence erodes trust, but naming the cost builds it. This transparency also models for my team that it is safe to name competing needs before they become crises, which is the third practice.

Psychological safety is built when leaders are honest about what they struggle with, what they are learning, and what they need. Edmondson and Besieux (2021) map how team members decide to speak up or stay quiet; my experience shows that when a leader speaks first about constraints and costs, team members feel safer doing the same. This is not manipulation. It is the foundation of shared vulnerability that allows difficult conversations to happen before they explode into crises, which is precisely what CCL (2025) aims to prevent.

Boyatzis et al. (2006) add an essential reminder: this is not just a mindset problem. It is measurable in how leaders' nervous systems operate. Sustainable leadership is built, triggered, and both at times. Cheung-Judge (2012) offers the discipline; Boyatzis et al. offer the biology. Together, they argue that sustainability is a real condition, not a luxury. For my career trajectory, whether I stay in Higher Education or disability-related work, or move onto something else, this framework becomes essential. Any role would require me to lead in resource-constrained environments where I cannot afford burnout or the blind spots that lead to it.

What I Still Need to Explore

This reading has clarified my questions rather than resolving them. First, how do leaders recognize the moment to switch between leadership styles before damage occurs? Benmira and Agboola (2021) identify the need but not the mechanism. In my experience, that recognition is difficult precisely because it requires the self-awareness that Kaplan and Kaiser (2003) show is unreliable. I will pursue this through regular feedback conversations with my supervisor and team, asking specifically: "When do you see me overusing one approach?"

Second, can psychological safety coexist with crisis mode? Edmondson and Besieux (2021) build a framework that assumes a baseline of safety, but my environment often does not permit that luxury. This tension is not resolved in the literature, and it is the most urgent for my work. I will test whether small acts of transparency, naming constraints early and inviting input rather than absorbing problems silently, can preserve psychological safety even in crisis.

Finally, I need to understand how to build durable feedback loops. Kaplan and Kaiser show leaders are blind; Cheung-Judge argues self-knowledge requires continuous investment; but neither explains how to structure that investment so it becomes sustainable practice rather than sporadic intent. This will shape how I approach supervision of my team: building regular check-ins where feedback on my leadership is expected and safe, not exceptional.

Conclusion

I still would place that Sighted Aide again without hesitation. What has changed is my understanding of what comes next. The gesture of solving the problem is only half the work. The harder, more necessary half is naming what the solution cost, inviting my team to help distribute those costs, and building a culture where urgent problems do not require silent sacrifice.

Sustainable leadership in urgent environments requires leaders to move outward from accurate self-knowledge (built with external feedback) through transparent communication about costs and constraints, to psychological safety where team members feel secure contributing what they see. This is not a soft skill. It is a structural requirement for organizations to adapt and survive in constraint. The articles I read this summer did not invent these practices, but they have given me language for why they matter and how they fit together. My work next will be to practice them, and to ask my team what they see in me that I do not see in myself, to name costs openly rather than absorb them silently, and to build conditions where difficult conversations happen early. That is the kind of leader I want to become.

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